

Acer Aspire One D250

Acer made a significant impact on the netbook market last year with its hugely popular Aspire One A110. It recently released a selection of new netbooks in its Aspire One range. The D250 we have here might not be a catwalk queen, but it looks attractive enough and benefits from a well-built chassis that doesn't creak under pressure.

Design

I was more impressed by the D250's girth—or rather, the lack of it. It's only an inch high. That's not as thin as ASUS' svelte Eee PC 1008HA—but is still much nicer than lots of other, chunky netbooks.

The D250 I reviewed makes use of Intel's 1.66GHz Atom N280, and Acer supplies it with 1GB of DDR 2 memory. Watch out, though: it's also available with the 1.6 GHz N270.

Ports

Two USB ports and a multi-format card reader are found on the right, along with the power socket. On the left sit the Ethernet, VGA, audio in/out and a third USB port. The vent is also on the left, and although the D250's fan fired up a fair amount during testing—even when doing little more than browsing the Web—it's not loud enough to irritate.

The battery

The rear is home to nothing but the three-cell 2200mAh battery. A six-cell version is also available, though this battery's a bulky affair that angles down from the notebook to lift the back of the machine up off the deck. It makes the machine less comfortable to carry—stick it in a bag so that it doesn't bother you. You may find that it angles the keyboard better.

At the front, you'll find a small Wi-Fi power switch—Bluetooth can be axed using a button just above the keyboard.

Storage

Flip the D250 on its belly and three removable backplates are revealed, providing access to the hard drive bay (home to a 160 GB 5400 rpm SATA drive), the memory and an empty Mini PCI Express slot. If you want to improve on the memory, you'll need to jettison the installed 1GB module, since the D250 only houses a single SO-Dimm slot.

Keyboard and touchpad

On the 8.9in A110, the keyboard took up almost the entire width of the chassis, barring a 1cm edge on either side of it. Admittedly, on a netbook there's not much room but even a slight enlarging of the keys would improve usability. Acer could also have switched to the flat-style of keys as found on its new Aspire One 751H netbooks. As it stands, the keyboard is a bit too fiddly to type on.

The trackpad measures just 50 x 30mm, and Acer has managed to furnish it with multi-touch capabilities, though these are fairly limited. You can zoom in and out by using a two-fingered pinching motion, while dragging two fingers left and right will perform functions such as navigating back and forth between Web pages and scrolling through an album of photos.

Display and networking bits

The 10.1-inch (25.6 cm) screen has a native resolution of 1024 x 600, and is bright, crisp and exhibits vibrant colours. Best of all, though, it performs amazingly well outdoors and even in direct sunlight I was able to see the desktop clearly. The only thing you'll need to watch out for when using it outside is the glossy screen attracting troublesome reflections.

Located just above the screen is a webcam, but it's only a 0.3 mega-pixel job.

The fact that Gigabit Ethernet has been sacrificed for bog standard 10/100MB/s wired networking won't concern too many prospective buyers, but Acer's decision to go for 802.11b/g wireless instead of 802.11n is surprising to say the least. Bluetooth is built-in.

Verdict

The Aspire One D250 weighs just 1.1 kg, making it one of the lightest 10-inch netbooks you'll find. Taking its lightweight nature into account, the fact that it managed to last two hours and twenty-four minutes through our video playback test, is admirable. You'll get even more back-up by going easier on the D250, and with a fully-charged battery, Jolicloud estimated there was enough juice for about three and a half hours of action.

Speaking of performance, when troubled with a bit of Gaussian Blur action in The Gimp, it took an average of 4.8 seconds to apply the filter to our standard test image.



▲ The hinge connecting the monitor and the keyboard makes the body look sleek



▲ The input ports are intelligently flushed within the body